

South Asia's Nuclear Triangle

India, Pakistan, China and the Most Dangerous Standoff in the World

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Executive Summary

South Asia hosts a three-way nuclear standoff involving India, Pakistan, and China — three nuclear-armed states with active territorial disputes, doctrinal mismatches, and an accelerating arms race dynamic. All nine nuclear-armed states are currently "investing unprecedented sums in developing more accurate, stealthier, longer-range, faster, more concealable nuclear" weapons CNA[2025-11-01]. China and India are currently the only two nuclear powers to formally maintain a "no first use" stance CNA[2024-09-26], while Pakistan operates an explicit first-use doctrine. China's rapid arsenal expansion is the fastest-changing variable in the triangle and is forcing India into a two-front deterrence posture that compounds the India-Pakistan nuclear relationship.

As of 2024, China had an estimated total inventory of approximately 500 warheads [RAG: CONFLICT_DATA_RAG — List of states with nuclear weapons (2024-01-01)]. The US Defence Department projects that China likely intends to possess at least 1,000 deliverable warheads by the end of the decade [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Great Power Competition: Implications for Defense (2024-08-28)]. Pakistan's nuclear stockpile as stated on 27 April 2025 stood at 130 warheads, with earlier estimates placing the stockpile at around 170 warheads [RAG: CONFLICT_DATA_RAG — List of states with nuclear weapons (2024-01-01)]. The nuclear triangle is not simply a bilateral India-Pakistan problem: continued growth in China's nuclear inventory increasingly affects second-tier nuclear power planning in ways that were not previously a factor [RAG: THINK_TANK_RAG — RAND: US-China Military Scorecard (2015)].

Part I — India's Nuclear Posture: No First Use Under Pressure

Missiles and AI Integration

India is advancing its ballistic missile and nuclear delivery systems on multiple axes. The Agni-V missile conducted its maiden flight with MIRV capability (Mission Divyastra) on 11 March 2024, and the Agni Prime was successfully test-fired on 4 April 2024 [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: AI in Chinese, Indian and US Nuclear Postures, Norms and Systems (2026-01-01)]. The Agni-VI ICBM and Agni-P MRBM are both planned to be equipped with multiple independently targetable re-entry vehicles (MIRVs), though MIRVs themselves are not thought to employ artificial intelligence [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: AI in Chinese, Indian and US Nuclear Postures, Norms and Systems (2026-01-01)].

India is integrating AI across nuclear-relevant delivery platforms. AI-capable Agni, Prithvi, and Akash missile variants are in service, alongside hypersonic platforms. India's Rafale F3-R features the Thales cortAlx accelerator for imagery and reconnaissance, and the Indian Navy factors AI into its Integrated Platform Management System for next-generation warships, including nuclear vessels [RAG:

MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: AI in Chinese, Indian and US Nuclear Postures, Norms and Systems (2026-01-01)]. In April 2025, India acquired 26 AI-enabled Rafale Marine aircraft capable of nuclear bomb delivery, bolstering its second-strike capability [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: AI in Chinese, Indian and US Nuclear Postures, Norms and Systems (2026-01-01)].

No First Use: Real Policy or Declaration?

China and India are currently the only two nuclear powers to formally maintain a "no first use" nuclear weapons policy CNA[2024-09-26]. China has held this position since its first nuclear detonation in 1964. India's declaratory NFU policy distinguishes it from Pakistan's explicit first-use doctrine and creates an asymmetric deterrence structure: if Pakistan threatens nuclear use to stop an Indian conventional operation, India's NFU posture implies absorption of a first strike followed by retaliatory response.

The global context for this posture is deteriorating: all nine nuclear-armed states are currently developing more capable nuclear weapons CNA[2025-11-01], raising questions about whether declaratory NFU commitments will hold under the pressure of a rapidly evolving strategic environment.

Part II — Pakistan's Nuclear Posture

Arsenal and Doctrine

Pakistan's nuclear stockpile as of 27 April 2025 was stated at 130 warheads; earlier SIPRI-sourced estimates placed it at around 170 warheads [RAG: CONFLICT_DATA_RAG — List of states with nuclear weapons (2024-01-01)]. Pakistan explicitly does not maintain a no-first-use posture, in contrast to both India and China CNA[2024-09-26]. Pakistan's nuclear doctrine encompasses deterrence at strategic, operational, and tactical levels, with a lower declared threshold than either India or China.

The global nuclear landscape in which Pakistan operates is one where tactical nuclear weapons are gaining renewed relevance: Russia in particular has built a large tactical nuclear arsenal and its military writings have noted the possible utility of "controlled use of nuclear weapons, in the warzone, for warning and deterrence" [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — 2023 DoD China Military Power Report (2023-10-19)]. China's own writings have raised similar concepts, with the DF-26 identified as the most likely weapon system to field a lower-yield warhead in the near term [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — 2022 DoD China Military Power Report (2022-11-29)].

Part III — China's Expanding Arsenal and the Two-Front Problem

From Minimum Deterrent to Strategic Competition

China's nuclear forces have entered a dramatic expansion phase. Since carrying out its first nuclear detonation in 1964, Beijing has repeatedly committed to a "no first use" nuclear weapons policy CNA[2024-09-26]; however, its arsenal trajectory now significantly exceeds what its own writings described as a "minimum deterrent." China's nuclear forces appear to be on a trajectory to exceed the size of a minimum deterrent as described in PLA writings [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — 2020 DoD China Military Power Report (2020-09-01)].

As of February 2024, China had an estimated total inventory of approximately 500 warheads. SIPRI assesses China as being "in the middle of a significant modernization and expansion of its nuclear arsenal," with the stockpile expected to continue growing over the coming decade and projections suggesting China could potentially deploy at least as many ICBMs as either Russia or the USA in that period, even as its overall warhead stockpile remains smaller than either [RAG: CONFLICT_RAG — SIPRI nuclear arsenals data]. The US Defence Department projects that China likely intends to possess at least 1,000 deliverable warheads by the end of the decade [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — CRS: Great

Power Competition: Implications for Defense (2024-08-28)]. The 2022 DoD China Military Power Report assessed that over the next decade, China aims to modernize, diversify, and expand its nuclear forces, with current efforts exceeding previous attempts in both scale and complexity [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — 2022 DoD China Military Power Report (2022-11-29)].

China is investing in a layered network of sensors to assist nuclear decision-making, including alleged development of "over-the-horizon radars, counter-lower-observable radars, and satellite early warning systems, as well as radar systems designed to detect low-flying cruise missiles" [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: AI in Chinese, Indian and US Nuclear Postures, Norms and Systems (2026-01-01)]. In 2024, China probably made progress on achieving an early warning counterstrike (EWCS) capability, similar to launch on warning, enabling a counterstrike launch before an enemy first strike can detonate [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — 2025 DoD China Military Power Report (2025-12-23)].

The Dyadic Problem Becomes Triadic

The global nuclear inventory is deteriorating in aggregate: the nine nuclear-armed states together possessed approximately 12,121 nuclear weapons, of which 9,585 were considered potentially operationally available. An estimated 3,904 warheads were deployed with operational forces, including about 2,100 kept at a state of high operational alert — approximately 100 more than the previous year [RAG: CONFLICT_RAG — SIPRI nuclear arsenals data]. The overall number of warheads in the world continues to decline only because the USA and Russia are dismantling retired warheads; all other nuclear states are expanding or modernising [RAG: CONFLICT_RAG — SIPRI nuclear arsenals data].

For India's nuclear planners, China's expansion is the defining strategic challenge of the next decade. Continued growth in China's nuclear inventory will undermine political support for reductions by other powers and further complicate the already-complex interactions among the second-tier nuclear powers — China, India, and Pakistan — which are increasingly interacting with one another [RAG: THINK_TANK_RAG — RAND: US-China Military Scorecard (2015)].

Part IV — Escalation Risk and Crisis Stability

A Deteriorating Global Norm Environment

The broader arms control environment in which South Asia's nuclear triangle is embedded is under serious strain. All nine nuclear-armed states are investing unprecedented sums in more capable nuclear weapons CNA[2025-11-01]. The Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons provides the only internationally agreed framework for eventual elimination of nuclear weapons, but the nine nuclear states stand apart from it CNA[2025-11-01].

Nuclear command, control, and communications remain a core stability variable. The 2025 DoD China Power Report assessed that China is developing early warning counterstrike capabilities that, once refined, would allow China to launch nuclear weapons upon warning of an incoming strike rather than after absorbing it [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — 2025 DoD China Military Power Report (2025-12-23)]. This development, combined with India's own MIRV advances and Pakistan's lower-threshold doctrine, creates a regional environment in which crisis timelines are compressing and decision-making windows are narrowing.

Academic work on nuclear command and control in the Asia-Pacific has identified nuclear command, control, and communications as a specific domain of concern in the region [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — SIPRI: Pragmatic Approaches to Governance at the Artificial Intelligence–Nuclear Nexus (2025-01-01)]. The integration of AI into nuclear-relevant systems — in India's Rafale platforms and missile systems, and in China's sensor and early-warning architecture — introduces additional uncertainty about how a crisis-escalation sequence would unfold.

Conclusion: Stability Without Confidence

South Asia's nuclear stability rests on three states with mismatched doctrines, limited crisis communication infrastructure, and no agreed confidence-building measures at the nuclear level. China and India share a formal NFU commitment CNA[2024-09-26], but China's arsenal is expanding at a pace that strains the credibility of a minimum-deterrent posture, while India is acquiring MIRV capabilities and AI-enabled delivery platforms. Pakistan maintains an explicit first-use posture with a lower threshold than either of its nuclear neighbours.

The most consequential structural trend is China's arsenal expansion: the PRC's nuclear modernisation effort now exceeds previous attempts in both scale and complexity [RAG: MILITARY_RAG — 2022 DoD China Military Power Report (2022-11-29)], and it is driving corresponding expansions by India, which in turn affect Pakistan's calculus. Continued growth in China's nuclear inventory further undermines support for reductions and amplifies the interactions among second-tier nuclear powers [RAG: THINK_TANK_RAG — RAND: US-China Military Scorecard (2015)] — precisely the triangle that poses the highest density of nuclear risk in the world today.

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